

A fearless, unsung hero

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In his memoir, *'Fearless,'* Mohinder Amarnath walks us through a triumphant yet tumultuous period of Indian cricket, placing himself in a fascinating twin role.

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The early parts of the book — which Mohinder has co-written with his brother Rajender — describe Mohinder's initiation to the sport under the watchful eyes of his father, Lala Amarnath, arguably India's first cricketing superstar.

These initial chapters drip with Mohinder's deference and admiration for his dad, which comes through in his interactions with other players and administrators, across the world.

A key part of Mohinder's early journey was his elder brother Surinder, who he calls a better batsman than him. Mohinder shares the deep bond he had with his sibling in their journey through the Indian domestic circuit and into the national team. But, Surinder eventually fades away from the narrative, which the writer attributes to that era's unfair selection process, which afflicted him too. Also worth highlighting is the multi-focal training model Lala designed for his sons. This included practising batting on grass without pads to counter spin and using wet tennis balls to prepare for bouncers

against pacers.

As expected, *'Fearless'* is rich with anecdotes collected by Mohinder over countless tours and tournaments. Interestingly, two such hilarious nuggets, where Mohinder steps into the role of a prankster, involve Sunil Gavaskar and missing shoes.

But on several other occasions, *'Fearless'* opts to blur out the identity of cricketers who were part of controversial stories, and understandably so. Among his colleagues, Mohinder is most candid about Gavaskar. The writer is open

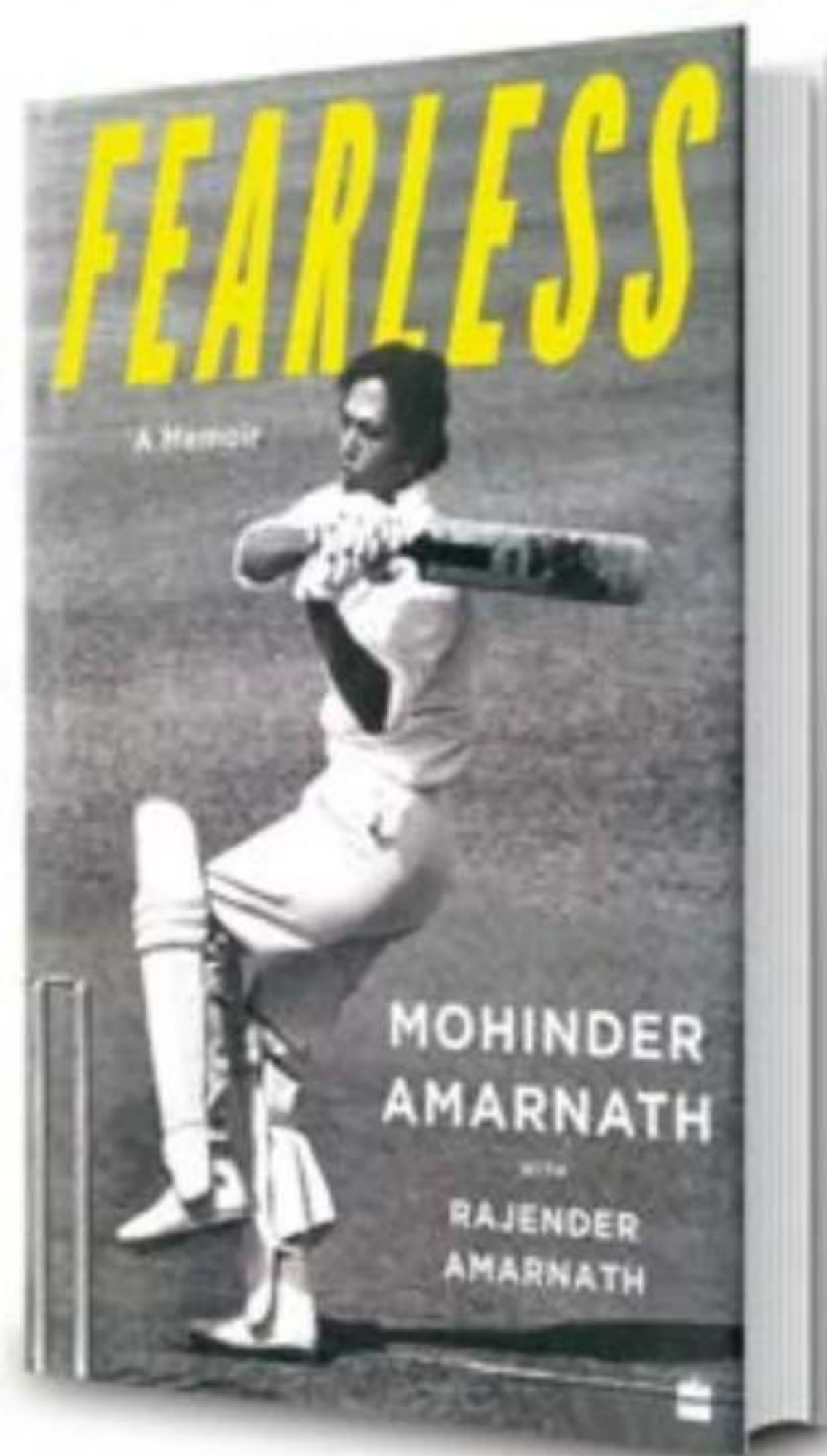
enough to requote Gavaskar's criticism of him early on in his career and then proudly brandishes the appreciation from the Little Master that followed later on.

Meanwhile, Mohinder's relationship with the administration, particularly the selectors, wasn't straightforward. Vast swathes of the memoir place Mohinder in exile when he was overlooked for national team selection for reasons beyond him. The conflict reaches its crescendo later on in the book, with Mohinder baring his version of his much-reported showdown with the selectors in 1988.

Another battle which defined Mohinder's career was the one against the short ball, which occupies a significant space in his recollection. This ranges from his early sense of control of it and the brief window where he was branded circumspect to the rising ball and his eventual mastery over it.

His combat with the short ball, which included multiple near-career-ending injuries and mental breakdowns, played a major role in the construction of his legacy and eventually lent a befitting title to this book.

'Fearless' is, however, scattered with editing errors, which is surprising, considering the obsessive gene running through the Mohinder family. Nevertheless, the narrative yarn is compelling enough for the reader to gloss over those minor faults, presenting one with a vibrant image not just of Mohinder Amarnath, but also of a fabled period of Indian cricket.



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